



Unit 1: Picking Tangerines

It was a beautiful day in late November, a day that Rick had been waiting to arrive for a long, long time. This was because it was the day that he would get to help his grandma pick tangerines and, without a doubt, they were his favorite fruit. He was terribly excited and couldn't wait to get going.

At the orchard, the sun shone gleefully down on several long rows of tangerine trees. Its bright rays reflected off the tangerines, making them sparkle and stand out amongst the green foliage like diamonds in a pile of coal. The scene almost made Rick cry with overwhelming joy.

"Here is your basket Rick," his elderly grandmother spoke, bringing him out of his dreamlike state. "When it's full, you can empty it into one of the boxes in the back of the truck."

Rick took the basket and began to fill it with the fresh tangerines. For each tangerine he picked, ten more would suddenly appear in its place. It almost seemed as if they were growing faster than he could pick them. When the basket was only half full, he begun to realize how daunting a task this was going to be.

"We're going to be here for the next month," Rick whined to his grandmother. "There must be a million tangerines here."

"Don't think about how many there are yet to pick, just focus on one tangerine at a time," his grandma advised him. She then added, "I like to make a game out of it."

“How do you do that?” Rick asked out of curiosity. He couldn’t imagine any way to make this fun.

“I time how long it takes to fill one box in the back of the truck. Then I try to beat that time when I fill the next box,” she explained. “It makes the time go by much faster.”

Rick suddenly felt competitive and challenged his grandma to see who could fill a box the fastest. He was going to try and beat her at her own game.

“I bet I can fill a box faster than you,” he said tauntingly.

“Ok,” she said. “But I have to warn you, I’ve got a few years of experience on my side. Not to mention that I have a big height advantage.”

The two spent the rest of the day racing to pick tangerines. They didn’t pick every tangerine in the orchard, but they certainly harvested enough to feed a jungle full of hungry monkeys. And they had a lot of fun doing it.